

Deserts and Steppe

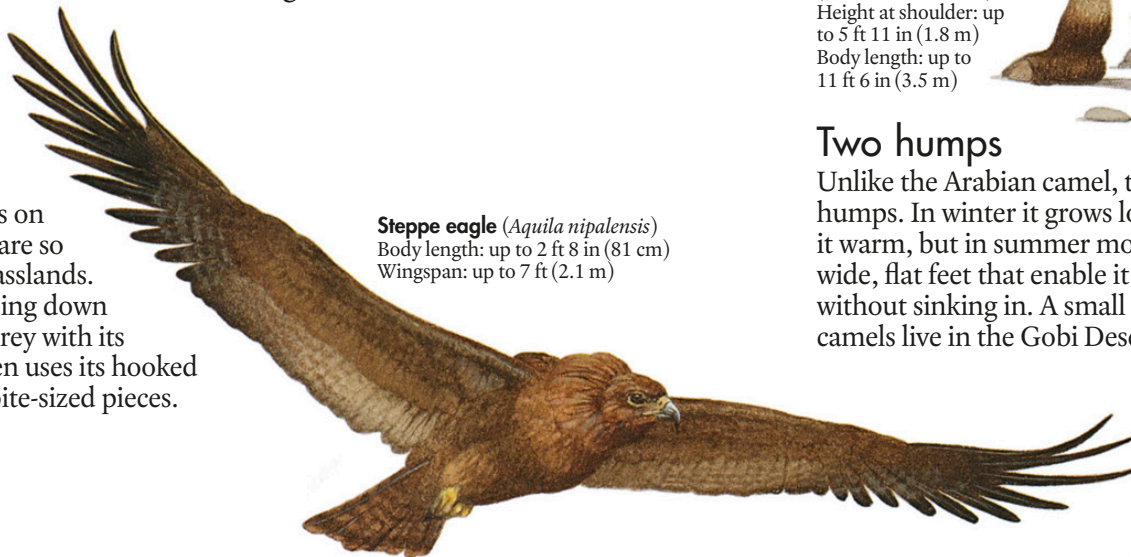


A VAST AREA OF GRASSLAND, called the steppe, stretches across the southern part of Russia and into China. The climate in this region consists of very hot summers and long, icy winters, with cold winds blowing down from the frozen north. Huge herds of grazing animals, such as saigas and onagers, once populated the steppe, but these have been almost wiped out by hunting. Some of the remaining herds are now protected, but they are forced to live in drier areas, away from farms.

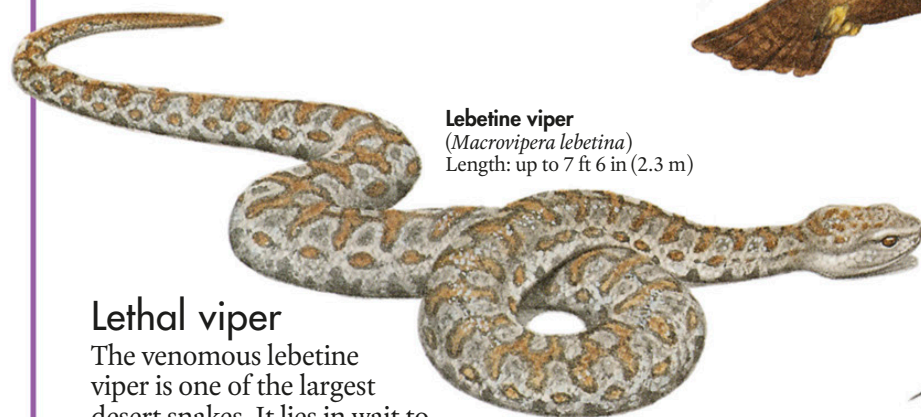
South of the steppe lie the deserts of central Asia, where rainfall is less than 12 in (30 cm) a year. Summers are baking hot, but at night the temperature can drop by as much as 36°F (20°C). Some desert animals sleep through the summer months; some come out only at night. Others have adapted to survive without drinking.

Rare eagle

The rare steppe eagle nests on the ground because there are so few trees on the steppe grasslands. It is a fierce hunter, swooping down out of the sky to seize its prey with its strong, sharp talons. It then uses its hooked beak to tear its food into bite-sized pieces.



Steppe eagle (*Aquila nipalensis*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 8 in (81 cm)
Wingspan: up to 7 ft (2.1 m)



Lebetine viper
(*Macrovipera lebetina*)
Length: up to 7 ft 6 in (2.3 m)

Lethal viper

The venomous lebetine viper is one of the largest desert snakes. It lies in wait to ambush the rodents and lizards on which it feeds, then injects venom into its prey through its long, hollow fangs. The viper waits for its victim to die and then swallows it whole. It hunts at night and rests in the shade or below ground during the heat of the day.



Cheek pouches

The hamster feeds on seeds, grain, roots, plants, and insects. In late summer, it stores large supplies of food in a network of tunnels that it digs beneath the steppe, carrying food in special cheek pouches. Hamsters have been known to store as much as 143 lb (65 kg) of food. The hamster hibernates in its burrow in winter, occasionally waking to eat.

Common hamster
(*Cricetus cricetus*)
Body length: up to 12.6 in (32 cm)
Tail: up to 2.7 in (6.8 cm)



Bactrian camel
(*Camelus bactrianus*)
Height at shoulder: up to 5 ft 11 in (1.8 m)
Body length: up to 11 ft 6 in (3.5 m)

Two humps

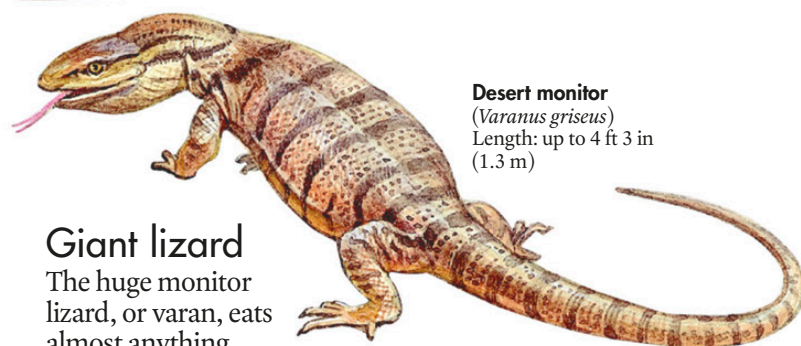
Unlike the Arabian camel, the bactrian camel has two humps. In winter it grows long, shaggy hair that keeps it warm, but in summer most of this hair falls out. It has wide, flat feet that enable it to walk over the soft sand without sinking in. A small number of wild bactrian camels live in the Gobi Desert.



Asiatic wild ass
(*Equus hemionus*)
Height at shoulder: up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)
Body length: up to 8 ft 2 in (2.5 m)

Fast runner

The Asiatic wild ass, or onager, can run at speeds of 40 mph (65 kph) or more—as fast as any racehorse. It can go for two or three days without drinking, which helps it survive in the dry conditions of the deserts and steppe. In summer it lives on the high grassland, but in winter it moves to lower levels for the fresh grass.



Desert monitor
(*Varanus griseus*)
Length: up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)

Giant lizard

The huge monitor lizard, or varan, eats almost anything, from other lizards and tortoises to rodents and birds. Sometimes it even eats its own young. It swallows its prey whole, like a snake. To frighten enemies away, the monitor lizard hisses loudly and lashes its powerful tail from side to side.